



Lining up for an escalator after arriving on an NJ Transit train at Penn Station in Manhattan. The 21-track layout is essentially the same as it was a century ago.

TODD HEISLER/THE NEW YORK TIMES

Despite Decades of Attempts, Penn Station Remains Broken

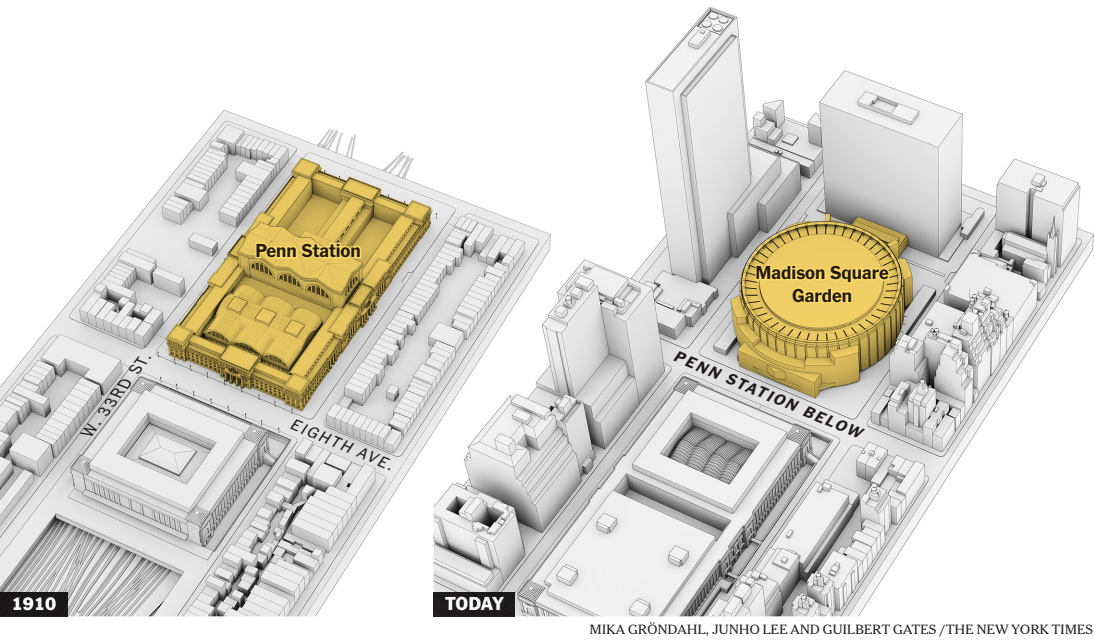
By PATRICK MCGEEHAN

In 1999, President Bill Clinton stood across the street from New York's Pennsylvania Station with the state's governor and its senior senator to announce plans for transforming the area into a modern gateway for the nation's big-city.

AMERICAN INERTIA

A Symbol of Stagnation

Presidents do not often appear at news conferences about train stations. But Penn Station, in Midtown Manhattan, was the busiest transportation hub in North America, and Mr. Clinton had made public transit a priority. He and Gov. George E. Pataki posed beside a miniature model of a grand new train hall, while Senator Daniel P. Moynihan extolled its future grandeur.



MIKA GRONDAHL, JUNHO LEE AND GUILBERT GATES/THE NEW YORK TIMES

Penn Station, Then and Now

When it opened in 1910, Penn Station was lauded as the largest building ever constructed at one time. Modeled after Rome's Baths of Caracalla, the Beaux-Arts station was built with pink granite and travertine marble.

Politics, Infighting and Powerful Interests Stand in the Way

"Penn Station is the start," Mr. Moynihan said, "and we will find — when we complete this project — that suddenly all will seem possible."

More than 25 years, five presidencies and four governors later, the plan to rebuild Penn Station is nowhere near completion.

For the 600,000 people who pass through it every day, Penn Station is indispensable. It remains the busiest transit hub in the United States, with nearly double the number of daily passengers as the busiest airport, Hartsfield-Jackson Atlanta International. Much of the Eastern Seaboard might grind to a halt

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A Rose Bowl Breakup Tears at L.A. Football Fans

By SHAWN HUBLER

PASADENA, Calif. — In Southern California, a place with more than its share of famous couples, few celebrity relationships have been as enduring as that of the Rose Bowl and the University of California, Los Angeles.

For 43 years, the Pasadena landmark has been the home field for the elite university's football program. Never mind that the stadium and the school are 26 miles apart. Marriage is cumulative, and U.C.L.A. and the Rose Bowl have had much to bind them: Four decades. Millions of dollars. An ironclad deal.

Or so it seemed until last month, when Pasadena officials went to court, claiming that U.C.L.A. had been plotting for months in secret to relocate to SoFi Stadium, a newer, closer and glitzier venue. Such a move, Pasadena said, would irreparably harm the Rose Bowl and the city, which owns the stadium and borrowed heavily to refurbish it on condition that the team would remain through June 2044.

The university, in a terse statement, said that "no decision has been made." But behind the scenes, Pasadena said, the university's lawyers had informed the city's lawyers that the school

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MARK ABRAMSON FOR THE NEW YORK TIMES

The Rose Bowl has uncomfortable seating and sublime sunsets.

Kennedy Told C.D.C. to Edit Risk of Autism

By SHERYL GAY STOLBERG

WASHINGTON — Health Secretary Robert F. Kennedy Jr. said in an interview that he personally instructed the Centers for Disease Control and Prevention to abandon its longstanding position that vaccines do not cause autism — a move that underscores his determination to challenge scientific consensus and bend the health department to his will.

In an interview on Thursday explaining why the C.D.C. website now says the claim that vaccines do not cause autism is not "evidence-based," Mr. Kennedy acknowledged that large-scale epidemiological studies of the measles, mumps and rubella vaccine had found no link to autism, and that studies of the mercury-based preservative thimerosal had also shown no link.

But he cited gaps in vaccine safety science. He said he ordered the C.D.C. to change its guidance in part because high-quality large studies had not been conducted to examine a potential link between autism and other shots given in the first year of life. Those include

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Trump and Mamdani Strike Optimistic Tone Across Divide

By TYLER PAGER and EMMA G. FITZSIMMONS

President Trump and Zohran Mamdani, the mayor-elect of New York City, put on a remarkable display of bonhomie in the Oval Office on Friday, with Mr. Trump showering praise on the democratic socialist and promising to help him succeed.

Just weeks ago, Mr. Trump was warning New York voters that electing Mr. Mamdani would amount to an existential threat to the nation's largest city.

"I expect to be helping him, not hurting him — a big help," Mr. Trump said, adding, "I think this mayor can do some things that are going to be really great."

For his part, Mr. Mamdani, who had vowed on the campaign trail to stand up to the president, called their meeting "productive" and said that he looked forward to working with Mr. Trump to improve life in New York.

Mr. Trump and Mr. Mamdani, who had lobbed labels like "com-

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ERIC LEE FOR THE NEW YORK TIMES

President Trump greeted Zohran Mamdani in the Oval Office.

INTERNATIONAL A4-9

Finding the Missing in Syria

Officials are exhuming bodies from scores of mass graves. Over 100,000 people vanished in the war. PAGE A4

South Africans Seize on G20

Protesters are using the summit meeting, the first held on African soil, to highlight domestic problems. PAGE A9



NATIONAL A10-21

His Yard Became a Battlefield

A Virginia man's yearslong war with his homeowners' association is an example of how the nation's partisan divide has reached the hyperlocal level. PAGE A10

Kennedy Center Gives 'Favors'

Under Richard Grenell, the institution has given steep discounts to CPAC and FIFA, signed contracts with Trump loyalists and spent lavishly. PAGE A17

The Border Wall Is Back

With a \$46.5 billion infusion from Congress, construction is again ramping up on the Rio Grande. But residents of Laredo, Texas, aren't happy. PAGE A16

BUSINESS B1-5

Dams in Disrepair

Demand for power is growing fast, but hydro plants are struggling because of droughts and other extreme weather linked to climate change. PAGE B1

Saudi's Plans Hit a Cash Crunch

The crown prince is handling a restructuring of the kingdom's fund after years of expensive investments. PAGE B1

SPORTS B6-9

Feasting on Cupcakes

For years, the top college football teams have been scheduling home games against lesser opponents. PAGE B6

TRAVEL C7-9

Canals Without the Crowds

The city of Leiden, with all the charm of Amsterdam, offers a variety of opportunities to expand your mind. PAGE C7

36 Hours in Cozumel

Off Mexico's Yucatán Peninsula, the island can feel comfortably uncrowded even amid all the cruise ships. PAGE C9



ARTS C1-6

The House That Netflix Built

The streamer has opened its first permanent home for branded fun, at a mall near Philadelphia. PAGE C1

Museums to Miss Art Patrons

With the deaths of two wealthy benefactors this year, the cultural megadonor may be a thing of the past. PAGE C1

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Gail Collins PAGE A23

